Through 1960, the US kept a close eye on the Sino-Indian boundary dispute, which showed no sign of dissipating. A summer intelligence estimate anticipated a stalemate with intermittent clashes. Over time, however, the dispute would become more dangerous, especially if Nehru was no longer prime minister. Intelligence officials did not foresee any turning back the clock in terms of Sino-Indian relations even if they reached a swap deal, the most likely solution.[106] Eisenhower, on his part, worried that China "might move" against India or Nepal or Southeast Asia.[107]

Nehru's conversations with Eisenhower and Herter in New York in fall 1960 reflected his continuing worries about China. He expressed uncertainty about Beijing's intentions and concern about the Chinese "national trait" to be expansive whenever Beijing felt confident. Sino-Indian talks, he asserted, had stalled because China was not clear about its claims. India, on its part, could only accept "minor deviation[s]." The president commented that communists tended to be "uncompromising" in negotiations. He asked if China's claims in the east would bring it to India's plains. Nehru answered that it would. He later told Herter that while his talks with Zhou had gone nowhere, Beijing had been "reasonable" and reached border agreements with Burma and Nepal—a Chinese attempt, as he saw it, to pressure India. Herter said that, at the very least, it would be good if China and India continued discussions. He asked about Indian public opinion. Nehru said it was "strong" against China and mentioned accusations in parliament that he was an "appeaser." Some, he said, were demanding India go to war with China, "as though one could go to war over those mountains."[108]

US intelligence assessments indicated that Chinese actions had not just created anti-China sentiment, but had also "tended to create in India a more sympathetic view of US policies." They expected the Chinese threat, along with a better understanding of the American approach and the need for American aid, to buoy the trend toward even better US-India relations. But, while analysts noted the weakening of the Communist Party in India (which eventually split in 1964 due to the Sino-Indian conflict), they were realistic about Delhi's attitude toward its other communist partner. They expected India to continue on its nonaligned path because of the need for Soviet aid and hope for Soviet restraint of China.[109]